

SELFIE TIME Vijay at a TVK roadshow in Perambur, Chennai, March 30

ANI

The Challenger's Court

The AIADMK finds itself at a particularly piquant crossroads as it heads into the 2026 Tamil Nadu assembly election. On the face of it, the party has massed a coalition that ticks many boxes, but these come with as many crosses. And what should be its greatest asset, proximity to New Delhi, is also its liability, "The AIADMK has faced several challenges since its inception in 1972," says veteran journalist Durai Karuna, who has tracked the party since its initial days. "But this election could easily be its toughest by far."

At the centre of the campaign is former chief minister EPS, projected as the principal face of the party. EPS has a few things going for him. He has the image of a good administrator, has been a relentless campaigner, and has taken the fight to the DMK camp on a number of issues, whether it be the plight of drought-affected farmers, police excesses, or the myriad corruption charges against the ruling party.

It might be late in the day, but EPS has also somewhat absolved himself of the DMK's charge of being a "slave of the BJP", especially in the way he handled seat distribution with the AIADMK's national party ally. Very few of the BJP's allotted 27 seats are in what they would consider their strongholds. Indeed, if the EPS camp is to be believed, they have also forced his old foe and ex-BJP state president K. Annamalai to sit out the election.

The saffron party, too, has been leaning towards its rarely seen pliant side, having learnt from the setbacks in 2021 and 2024. As one BJP source put it, the party has "moved from assertion to accommodation" in the state. It has also accepted its role as a junior partner, conceding ground to the AIADMK even in its key regions like the Kongu belt (particularly Coimbatore) in the larger interests of the alliance.

Where EPS has faltered is in the alliance consolidation that once defined the Jayalalithaa era. The post-2016 churn since her death has produced multiple power centres: former Jayalalithaa aide V.K. Sasikala, once a powerful entity in the AIADMK, has launched her own party. And OPS, the ex-CM handpicked by Jayalalithaa to fill her shoes, has switched sides and is now contesting as a DMK candidate. Karuna says Sasikala could chip away at some of the AIADMK votes in the south, mobilising sections of her Mukkulathor (Thevar) community, historically a key tonal strand on the Jayalalithaa rainbow. The AIADMK counter: Sasikala's nephew, T.T.V. Dhinakaran, is on its side, but this still leaves a splintered vote base.

All this on the eve of the election gives an unsettled look to the AIADMK-led NDA alliance arithmetic, say observers. Even the party's ties with the BJP have oscillated between cooperation and dissonance. On sensitive issues like delimitation and minority outreach, the AIADMK has been treading carefully, with EPS even declaring that the alliance with the BJP is only "for the election".

Compounding this is the situation within the Pattali Makkal Katchhi (PMK), another NDA ally. Party founder S. Ramadoss and his son Anbumani Ramadoss are at odds with each other and the split in the ranks has raised questions about its support on the ground. Any haemorrhaging in the PMK's base could affect the AIADMK's plans in northern Tamil Nadu, where the former has a hold on sections of the Vanniyar vote.

Sasikala has also teamed up with

The AIADMK also faces competition from newer political entrants. Actor Vijay's TVK is expected to draw anti-incumbency votes that might otherwise have gravitated toward the party